

MERCURY AND VENUS

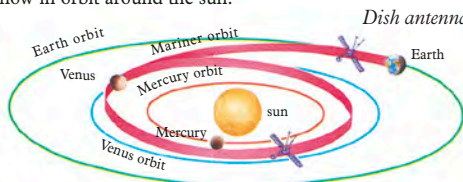
Between the Earth and the sun are two planets called Mercury and Venus. They are very hot because they are the sun's nearest neighbors. Venus is the brightest object in the night sky. Mercury is the smallest planet in the solar system. Photographs from space probes tell us more about these planets.

Hello, goodbye!

Mariner 10, intended to explore Mercury and Venus, was the first probe to visit two planets in a row. It worked for 17 months before breaking down. Launched in 1973, it is now in orbit around the sun.

The solar detector made sure that the solar panels were always facing the sun.

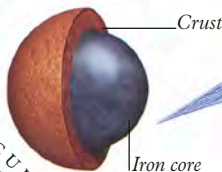
Television cameras sent pictures back to Earth.



The Journey of Mariner 10

Happy new year

Mercury travels fast through space and is the closest planet to the sun. The Earth orbits the sun every 365 days—one Earth year. Mercury's year is 88 days.



Hard center

If you could slice Mercury like a peach, you would find it had a core made of iron.



Mariner 10

